

PSYC1022 Essay Instructions T2 2026

Read the following vignette and then follow the essay instructions detailed below:

Rajan has been using cocaine for five years. Initially, he only used it occasionally at social gatherings, typically every other weekend. He recalls how, when he first started, the effects were very enjoyable. Right after taking cocaine, he would experience an intense rush of euphoria that left him feeling energised, confident, and very sociable, and using cocaine was incredibly pleasurable. As time passed, Rajan found he needed more cocaine to achieve the same intense euphoria he felt when he first began using it. These days, Rajan uses cocaine almost daily, whether he's at work or home alone, and his cocaine use is becoming a significant problem. He's spending a considerable amount of money on it, so he's trying to limit his use to just weekends. During the week, however, he finds this extremely challenging because, without cocaine, he experiences strong cravings, everyday life feels dull and uninteresting, and he is constantly exhausted and low in mood. Rather than waiting for the weekend, Rajan ends up using cocaine again to feel better. He has also noticed that his cravings are strongest in particular situations: whenever he sees the friends he used to take cocaine with, or walks past the nightclub where he first started using, he is hit by a powerful urge to use, even on days when he had promised himself he would stay clean.

Instructions

The essay requires you to read the vignette above and identify critical features of cocaine addiction. You need to:

1. *Identify* and *explain* two associative learning concepts embedded in the vignette that explain how cocaine use is *established* and how it is *maintained*.
2. *Describe* and *integrate* the neuropharmacological processes and changes in the dopaminergic system that underpin the two behaviours identified in part 1 above.

Essay Format

A single, 1200 word essay must be submitted through the Turnitin portal on the PSYC1022 Moodle page by 5.00 pm Sydney time on Monday of Week 9. The essay contributes 60% to your overall mark in the course.

- The 1200 word limit is very strict. There will be a 5% penalty for a word count of 1201-1250, plus a further 5% penalty for every 50 words thereafter. Thus, an essay of 2200 words would receive a mark of 0 (The "10% over rule" does not apply here).
- In-text citations and any subheadings are included in the word count.
- The reference list itself does not form part of the word count, nor does the title, or other peripherals such as your name and student ID number.

- You will not be penalized for going under the word count. However, if you do go under the word count then you should ensure that you are addressing all the instructions and providing sufficient detail (see: "Things to consider" below).
- If you choose to include appendices in your essay then these will be included in the word count. You should ask yourself if you really need appendices before including them - information pertinent to answering the question should be included in the main body of the essay.
- If you choose to include figures or tables within your essay, make sure that the figure caption contains sufficient information to understand its content. In addition to this, you should not present new information or arguments in your figure captions that is not mentioned within the main body of your essay (Figure captions/headings do not contribute to the word count).
- Do not include an abstract in your essay.
- Formatting (i.e. document setup parameters such as margins, line spacing, font size & type, paragraph indents, etc.) and referencing (both in-text citations and the reference list) are to be done using APA style (as per the APA manual's 7th edition). See: [APA 7th ed.](#) and <https://apastyle.apa.org/instructional-aids/reference-guide.pdf>. A copy of the manual can be found in the library. A sample paper with this formatting is provided in the "Assessment 3" hub. These APA conventions are also covered in the APA style online lesson released in Week 2.
- It is expected that submissions adhere to the standard format of all academic essays (i.e. introduction, body, conclusion). It is assumed that students have polished academic essay writing skills, if not, it is highly recommended that students seek assistance with essay writing skills prior to submitting this assessment. Poor academic writing skills will negatively impact the mark achieved in this piece of assessment. For help with academic writing see: <http://www.lc.unsw.edu.au/>. Feedback on a draft is also available from the Studiosity platform and is the basis of Essay Prep task 2.

Submission Guidelines

- Submit a .doc/.docx file to the Turnitin link—no PDFs please. Take care when selecting the file to upload to ensure that it is the correct version and not a draft. Please ensure you upload the correct file: if an incorrect file is submitted, it may not be possible for the Course Convenor to upload the correct version on your behalf, and a late penalty may apply.
- Late penalties will be applied according to university policy. Unless an extended deadline has been granted, if an assignment is submitted late but within five days (120 hours) of the initial deadline, 5% of the maximum possible mark for that assignment will be deducted for each day (including weekend days) it is overdue. Students can submit an assessment late, incurring the late penalty, until the "overdue submission deadline." The overdue submission deadline is five days (120 hours) after the initial deadline (i.e., Saturday of Week 9 5pm). Any assessment submitted after the overdue submission deadline will not be marked and will result in a mark of zero for the assessment. Your submission time is determined by the timestamp recorded in Moodle; this is what will be used to determine whether an assignment is overdue.
- **Extended deadlines via Special Consideration:** If circumstances outside a student's control have impacted their ability to submit an assessment before the initial deadline, they may apply to have the late penalty waived, via a Special Consideration application through the [online portal](#). If the central team grant you Special Consideration, an extension up to a maximum of 10 working days



past the initial deadline may be provided. *Do not email Special Consideration requests to the Course Convenor. Requests sent via email may not receive a response.*

- **Extended deadlines via Equitable Learning Plan:** If a student is registered with UNSW Equitable Learning Services (ELS), and an Equitable Learning Plan (ELP) authorises extensions for assignment submission, you are required to email the Course Convenor to request the ELP extended deadline adjustment be activated.
- **Under both ELP and Special Consideration circumstances an absolute fail deadline applies.** *Under no circumstances will an extension be given beyond when marks and feedback on the assessment is provided to students (10 working days from the initial deadline).* Neglecting to submit an assignment by the absolute fail deadline will result in a mark of 0 for the assignment, unless Special Consideration has been granted to undertake a supplementary assessment. Please read the Psychology Student Guide for more detailed information about this policy.
- Marks and feedback will be returned to students 10 working days from the due date.

Plagiarism

- Please familiarize yourself with UNSW's policy on plagiarism. This is very important. Plagiarism is a serious academic offence. **This course takes all forms (e.g. inappropriate citation and/or paraphrasing, excessive quoting, copying, collusion, self-plagiarism, etc.) of plagiarism seriously and action will be taken if plagiarism is identified in your work.** For more information see: <https://student.unsw.edu.au/plagiarism>.
- *Originality reports will not be available to students.* It is the student's responsibility to ensure that their work is original and free of plagiarism prior to submission. If there are issues with your originality report you will be contacted by the School of Psychology in due course.
- Please take steps to avoid your marker finding plagiarism in your work. This is a good resource: <https://student.unsw.edu.au/path-avoiding-plagiarising>.

Chat GPT and other generative AI tools

It is important to read the "Responsible use of Generative AI tools: A guide for students" (located underneath these essay instructions) in the "Essay Hub" in Moodle. Lecturers in the School of Psychology design assessment to help you attain the competencies prescribed by APAC, the psychology accreditation body that oversees all psychology programs in Australia. These competencies emphasise psychology as a scientific discipline, research methods, values and ethics, critical thinking, and scientific communication skills. In the vast majority of cases, using generative AI tools like chatGPT to complete your assessment will not aid you in gaining these competencies. In fact, the output from tools like chatGPT is often inaccurate, overly general, and poorly referenced. As this assessment task involves some planning or creative processes, you are permitted to use software to generate initial ideas. However, you must develop or edit those ideas to such a significant extent that what is submitted is your own work, i.e. only occasional AI generated words or phrases may form part of your final submission. It is a good idea to keep copies of the initial prompts to show your lecturer if there is any uncertainty about the originality of your work. If the outputs of generative AI such as ChatGPT form a part of your submission, it will be regarded as serious academic misconduct and subject to the standard penalties, which may include 00FL, suspension and exclusion.

To be clear, you are permitted to use AI tools for planning or design assistance only (for example, to help generate or organise initial ideas). AI must not be used to write the content of your essay. If over-reliance on AI is suspected or detected in your work, this will be investigated and you will be contacted



by the Course Convenor. In the event that your work is investigated for over-reliance on AI, you may be asked to produce evidence of your own work and process. You should therefore keep, and be able to produce on request: a record of any AI interactions used for planning or design (including your prompts and the outputs); copies of all drafts of your essay (i.e., your writing prior to your final submission); and PDF copies of the literature you cite (preferably with your own notes or annotations on the reading you have done).

Things to consider – What makes a good essay?

- You may choose to address each part of the instructions sequentially or you may take a more integrated approach. Subheadings are optional.
- Make sure you read these instructions in conjunction with the essay marking rubric provided in Moodle. The marking rubric explains how marks are distributed across part 1 and 2 and the criteria for each component.
- You need to select appropriate literature to cite in your essay (i.e. websites, blogs, etc. are not considered appropriate sources; published scientific literature, DSM-5 are appropriate). You should use scientific evidence (e.g. published journal articles) to support your discussion. *Please do not cite the lecture notes.*
- For part 1 you need to identify and explain the associative learning concepts with reference to scientific journal articles, as well as any relevant psychological theories or models. (i.e. how has this concept been shown in scientific research). You must make clear the relevance of the associative learning concepts to addiction (i.e. how do these concepts in the vignette establish and maintain cocaine use and lead to relapse/inability to abstain from cocaine).
- For part 2 you need to describe and integrate the dopaminergic processes and changes involved in the behaviours identified in part 1 (i.e. what happens at a neurological level that supports initial cocaine use and what adaptations take place that maintain chronic cocaine use). It is important to focus on the dopaminergic system and discuss why processes and changes within this system are important for understanding addiction. You need to support these discussion points with scientific literature .
- You should ensure that you explicitly define cocaine addiction and any models, theories, or concepts you discuss in your essay. When you explain these things in your own words you are demonstrating that you understand these concepts and the literature.
- You should not simply list a general description of facts. Instead, you need to clearly discuss important concepts in the literature and research evidence and then provide a detailed explanation of how/why these points are relevant to addiction.
- The number of references you use is not important or an indication of essay quality. A high quality response can achieve a strong argument by carefully selecting *a few good research papers and discussing them in sufficient detail* to effectively support their argument.
- Avoid relying too heavily on review papers that express the opinion of others. *You need to locate the scientific evidence, evaluate it and formulate your own opinions.* Often review papers are a good place to start reading on a topic so you can get an overview of the scientific literature that already exists. Reference lists of relevant review papers can point you in the direction of published research on a given topic which you can then read yourself to form your own opinion.



- The quality of essays will be judged on *the clarity of the information provided*, and the *integration of scientific evidence into your discussion*. The marking will be based on the strength of your discussion and the clarity of your expression. When writing in science, the key is to *clearly explain complex ideas*. With this in mind, the audience you are writing for is an intelligent person who is ignorant of addiction/substance use disorder (doing this demonstrates to your marker that you understand the material).
- If possible, you should ask family and/or friends to read over your article and see if they understand what you have written. If they understand and are convinced by what you are trying to say, and how any research was conducted and what it found, then you have done a good job. If they are struggling to understand a section or do not know how some of the research was conducted or what it found, then it is likely that you should re-write the section to fix this.

